Professor Sir Ian Chapman FREng FRS FInstP
Chief Executive
UK Research and Innovation

Reforming UKRI Eligibility **18th August 2026**

Dear Ian,

A strong and adaptable research system is essential to advancing knowledge, improving lives and driving growth. We welcome UKRI's continued efforts to strengthen that system.

The success of this agenda depends on the organisations that UKRI funds. Currently, a large majority of UKRI's research funding flows to universities. While universities are home to many genuinely world-class research capabilities, not all research is best done in academic settings by researchers responding to academic incentives. As the 2023 Nurse Review recognised, "the UK [research, development, and innovation] landscape would also benefit from greater inclusivity and the creation of more diverse Research Performing Organisations".

New research organisations can do things differently and will be a better fit for some types of science and technology. For example, Bind Research is building the public-good datasets needed to turn disordered proteins into viable drug targets, a large-scale challenge ill-suited to either an academic lab or a business. Asterisk Labs is creating free, open tools and datasets to tackle the climate crisis, public goods that are often created outside traditional research organisations, which prioritise new ideas and papers over new tools. Amodo is supplying dozens of research teams with professional engineering capability no single lab could sustain in-house.

The opportunity afforded by new organisations like these is already enormous and is set to grow. Hundreds of billions of dollars are coming down the philanthropic pipeline, and Britain can claim more of this dividend if it is visibly open to innovative research organisations, including those which are best placed to capitalise on AI. A dynamic system of research institutions would promote the evolution of the research base, broaden the types of research that can be funded, and improve the value that UKRI delivers for the public. But a dynamic system requires dynamic funders.

Successive governments have recognised the value new research organisations can provide, backing the Research Ventures Catalyst to seed new types of research organisation. ARIA also funds schemes to foster Focused Research Organisations (FROs) and Frontier Research Contractors (FRCs). These initiatives reflect a clear understanding that significant research capability exists beyond established universities and institutes, and that this capability can benefit the UK.

Despite this, UKRI's eligibility rules mean that new research organisations can only access taxpayer-funded infrastructure, facilities, and funding calls via university partners if at all, and not independently. This is true even when those new organisations are explicitly backed by government and are home to some of the UK's best scientists.

UKRI should seek to fund the best research with public benefit, selecting on the basis of quality rather than organisational form. As your UKRI strategy sets out, “research assessment ensures investment goes where excellence thrives, but excellence comes in many forms.”

UKRI has rightly taken steps to adapt its eligibility criteria, including by removing arbitrary requirements for a minimum number of PhDs, and streamlining its review of organisational policies. We look forward to seeing more research organisations become eligible as these reforms become familiar to the sector and UKRI grantmakers. But significant barriers remain, and there is a clear opportunity for UKRI to go further while still maintaining full control over which institutions receive funding and access to infrastructure or talent.

To become eligible, organisations are asked to provide three years of audited accounts and evidence of three years averaging £0.5 million research income or expenditure. This is a de facto ban on supporting new organisations. Additionally, UKRI’s eligibility system classifies certain organisations as “non-standard” based on their corporate structure alone, excluding organisations like social enterprises or charities from almost all support. In practice, many highly capable non-academic organisations cannot access UKRI support directly. Implementing two technical changes would go a long way to fixing this.

First, **UKRI should remove the de facto ban on supporting new organisations. It should achieve this by offering a forward-looking route through which new organisations can demonstrate research capability and financial viability. Significant financial support from funders that UKRI already trusts should provide such a route.** To that end, UKRI should publish a list of trusted funders, including at a minimum those on the existing list of endorsed funders, and should update it regularly.

Second, **UKRI should remove the artificial distinction between standard and non-standard eligibility.** The requirements for standard eligibility are practically identical to those for the highest band of non-standard eligibility, yet organisations meeting these materially equivalent criteria are treated differently. This distinction blocks organisations with non-standard eligibility from accessing support, even when they have been deemed to have sufficient research capability and appropriate financial governance. **If non-standard eligibility must be kept, UKRI’s Executive Committee should mandate all calls to be open by default to organisations with either type of eligibility.**

These reforms, which are detailed in the annex, would improve UKRI’s ability to choose the strongest research without lowering its standards or weakening its financial controls. They would improve the quality and value for money of the research UKRI supports, increase institutional dynamism, and open new pathways to prosperity across the country. We look forward to working with you to achieve UKRI’s mission.

We have copied this letter to the Science Minister, and we will be making it available online.

Yours sincerely,

The undersigned

SCIENCE WORKS

Convergent Research

Royal Academy of Engineering

Renaissance Philanthropy

amodo

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zinc INNOVATION PARTNERS

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Cultivarium

asterisk labs

BASIS

Deep Science Ventures

Living Physics Lab

Logicians.

London Institute for Mathematical Sciences

The Independent Science Society

SYNTATO

Annex A

Technical changes to UKRI eligibility processes

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1. Eligibility for new organisations

Challenge

The current eligibility requirements exclude all new research organisations, even if they have significant research capability and capacity, because they cannot provide three years of audited accounts and evidence of three years of research income or expenditure. This severely hinders UKRI's ability to respond to emerging opportunities and support the best research. For example, FROs, which have a limited time horizon despite their strong research capabilities, cannot access UKRI funding or infrastructure until at least three years after they start. By this point, they will often be more than halfway to closing. So, the British public misses out on the opportunity to use the research capability embedded in the FRO to make progress on government and societal priorities.

Solution

We propose that UKRI establishes a two-track model for proving delivery capability and financial viability. The first track maintains the current approach: organisations need to provide three years of audited accounts, evidence of three years averaging £0.5 million annual research income or expenditure, and associated statements. The second track replaces the lagging "three years" requirements with a new forward-looking requirement: that the research organisation has, within the last three years, received financial commitments worth at least £1.5 million, including £0.5 million from funders on a new list of trusted funders. Moving to this forward-looking assessment would remove the biggest blocker to UKRI supporting new types of research organisation, while also allowing those organisations to raise more philanthropic capital in expectation of this support.

The new list of trusted funders should be owned by UKRI and updated regularly. At a minimum, it should include all funders on the existing list of endorsed funders, each of which "is an organisation accepted by UK Research and Innovation as a prestigious funder of research and innovation" with "an excellent track record". Because this list of endorsed funders includes government departments, this fixes an existing problem whereby organisations to which the government has given millions of pounds remain ineligible for UKRI support. UKRI should also add other prestigious and trusted research funders to the list, such as the Volkswagen Foundation, SPRIND, the Schmidt Family Foundation, the Sloan Foundation, and Coefficient Giving.

Leveraging the judgement of trusted funders would be an effective way to identify research capability: the government and UKRI already place significant trust in these funders, giving them an important role in determining who enters the country. It would also safeguard value for money: endorsed funders require applicants to show that they can be trusted to deliver value on a substantial investment, and applicants would still be subject to UKRI's other eligibility conditions, including those relating to financial and governance controls.

So, this new pathway would fulfil UKRI's financial assurance responsibilities, while improving its ability to support the best-quality research capability. It would also reduce bureaucratic duplication through funder coordination, as recommended by the Tickell Review of research bureaucracy.

2. Mainstreaming non-standard eligibility

Challenge

Almost all of UKRI's research grant calls are run using standard eligibility only. In July, more than 90% of open calls were not open to organisations with non-standard eligibility. This makes it impossible for organisations with non-standard eligibility to access the vast majority of UKRI's support, whether that is funding, access to infrastructure, or talent fellowships. This exclusion is not well justified. Organisations applying for the highest band of non-standard eligibility, who can apply for grants worth more than £200,000, have to meet materially the same criteria as those applying for standard eligibility as Independent Research Organisations. Charities, non-governmental organisations, government departments, third-sector organisations, social enterprises, and other educational establishments can all meet the requirements to be an Independent Research Organisation with standard eligibility. Indeed, some already have. Diverting them into non-standard eligibility on the basis of organisational structure alone is hard to justify.

Solution

We propose removing the artificial distinction between standard and non-standard eligibility, while maintaining a low-friction pathway for organisations seeking less than £200,000. This would allow UKRI to choose to support British social enterprises, charities, and NGOs, if assessors decide that this is the best way to achieve UKRI's goals. This merged eligibility structure should include British for-profit social enterprises provided that profit is reinvested for social purposes, as the non-standard eligibility criteria already do.

If non-standard eligibility must be maintained, we propose that UKRI's Executive Committee adopts a policy requiring all grant calls to be opened by default to institutions with standard and non-standard eligibility, being restricted to standard eligibility only where a good case can be made to do so.